THE BALLOT CONUNDRUM

ONOP promises cost efficiency and stable governance; critics say it'll centralise power, weaken regional forces

PROS

- **Cost efficiency:** Conducting simultaneous elections will reduce expenses
- **Seamless governance:** Frequent polls along with Model Code of Conduct disrupt governance
- **Administrative streamlining:** A single electoral roll and synchronised elections would reduce burden on administrative and security forces
- **Focus on development:** Continuous polls make governments focus on short-term populist policies rather than long-term development

CONS

- **Blow to federalism:** Simultaneous polls can centralise power and weaken regional parties, as national issues overshadow local ones
- **Logistical challenge:** Organising simultaneous polls across the large, diverse country presents a logistical nightmare in terms of security and administrative personnel
- **Mid-term poll complications:** In case a government falls before its term ends, holding fresh elections will disrupt the synchronised cycle. Mid-term polls will complicate the system

litical parties. Synchronised elections could also reduce the 'electoral fatigue' among voters, they claim.

WHY THE CRITICISM?

Critics argue that the ONOP proposal runs counter to the core principles of federalism and infringes on states' autonomy. They contend that imposing synchronised elections erodes democratic choice by forcing an artificial electoral cycle, limiting the freedom of voters. Former Lok Sabha secretary-general P.D.T. Achary has warned that stripping states of the power to recommend the dissolution of their assemblies would violate federalism and the Constitution's Basic Structure Doctrine.

In a unified election, the risk, critics note, is that voters may confflate national and state elections, casting their ballots based on national issues even in state polls, which would likely favour large national parties and marginalise regional contenders.

There are additional risks associated with making state assembly terms contingent on the Lok Sabha's tenure. The shift to synchronised elections might discourage Opposition parties from introducing no-confidence motions, as the shortened tenure for any subsequent government would offer little incentive to dissolve an administration prematurely.

Critics also challenge the proposal's claim to fully synchronised elections, pointing out that it excludes local body elections, which represent a significant portion of elected officials. "Over three million local representatives will be excluded, compared to just 5,000 (MPs and MLAs combined) included," says former chief election commissioner S.Y. Quraishi. "Holding local polls three months later would require a repeat of the extensive logistical preparations—polling stations, training staff, redeploying security forces—and would disproportionately affect daily-wage workers who may be unable to vote in multiple rounds of elections." Also, the massive ramping up of the EVM infrastructure to enable simultaneous polling, he points out, deflates the cost-cutting argument.

Another concern is the potential to skew voting patterns in favour of the ruling party at the Centre. Historically, India's first four general elections, which were held simultaneously, saw the Congress dominate both national and state governments. Data from the IDFC Institute, a Mumbai-based think tank, reveals that between 1999 and 2014, in cases where national and state elections were held concurrently, an average 77 per cent of voters chose the same party for both (it reached 86 per cent in 2014). By contrast, in instances where national and state elections were held separately but within six months of each other, the alignment dropped to 61 per cent, and in broken election cycles, the figure fell to 48 per cent. Political analyst Amitabh Tiwari says this trend continued even between 2014 and 2024, giving heft to the view that simultaneous elections benefit dominant national parties.

Bibek Debroy, chair of the Economic Advisory Council to the Prime Minister and author of a 2017 NITI Aayog report on simultaneous elections, disputes this. He argues that voting patterns are shaped by a range of factors, not just the timing of elections. "There are numerous cases where voters have supported the same party in both state and national elections, even when they were not held simultaneously," Debroy observes, pointing out that reducing the complexity of voter behaviour to a single variable overlooks the nuanced maturity of the Indian electorate.

The idea of ONOP is not new. The EC first proposed it back in 1983. The push for it, though, represents a bold yet contentious vision for India's electoral future. The true challenge lies in building consensus across the political spectrum to ensure any reforms strengthen, rather than erode, the democratic process. ■